(upgrade of the level of capital's organic composition) and, as a new synthesis of many determinations is again externalised (sub-imperialist expansion), alters the way world capitalism operates.

> Sub-imperialism corresponds to the perverse manifestation of world differentiation as a result of capitalist internationalisation, which counterpoises a much more complex system of relationships to the simple structure of a division of labour – crystallised in the centre-periphery relationship that preoccupied ECLA. In it, the spread of manufacturing elevating the average national organic composition of capital, that is, the relationship existing between the means of production and the working class gives way to economic (and political) sub-centres endowed with relative autonomy even though they remain subordinated to the global dynamic imposed by the great centres (Marini 1992:137–8).

The perverse sense to which Marini refers is the fact that relative autonomy cannot escape the global dynamic imposed by the great centres. When one or more dependent economies ascend to a new level in the world capitalist hierarchy, they take on a new character of dependency and are also converted into extractors of surplus value, appropriating a portion of the value produced in the peripheries – but without raising the general standard of living of their working class.[5] As already stated: 'capital accumulation's tendency to concentrate and centralise progresses even though now also in the interests of nations of an intermediate organic composition.' In summary, the general tendencies of the world economy and system are crystallised and take the form of certain specific social formations as much to breathe life into imperialism as into sub-imperialism.

A stage of dependent capitalism

In the same way Lenin described imperialism as the highest stage of capitalism, sub-imperialism for Marini consisted of 'the form that dependent capitalism takes when it reaches the monopoly and finance capitalism stage' (Marini 1977a:31). It is a superior level of development in which, 'due to its dependent and subordinate manner, Brazil would enter the capital-exporting stage as well as in the pillage of external energy sources such as petroleum, iron and natural gas' (Marini 1977a:32).

In this sense, a dependent country's arrival at the sub-imperialist stage establishes a sub-regional division benefiting sub-imperialist capital visible by the appropriation of the surplus value of weaker nations. These nations are